

# Don't Burn Through Your Tokens

Think of AI usage like an arcade. Every session, you're inserting tokens. The claw machine costs **1 token per play**, but the full-on VR racing simulator costs **25**. The VR rig is more impressive, sure, but if you just want to grab some candy, it's complete overkill. Claude works the same way: four model tiers, each one significantly pricier than the last. Matching the right model to your task keeps everyone's budget healthy.



## QUICK REFERENCE – PICK YOUR MACHINE

| TIER & MODEL                       | RELATIVE COST                     | BEST FOR                                                                                          |
|------------------------------------|-----------------------------------|---------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| <b>Basic</b><br><i>Haiku 4.5</i>   | ● ○ ○ ○ ○<br><i>1× baseline</i>   | Simple Q&A, quick lookups, translations, short summaries, reformatting text or data               |
| <b>Standard</b><br><i>Sonnet 5</i> | ● ● ○ ○ ○<br><i>~4× baseline</i>  | Writing & editing, analysis, coding help, brainstorming, research – most everyday work            |
| <b>Advanced</b><br><i>Opus 4.8</i> | ● ● ● ● ○<br><i>~15× baseline</i> | Complex multi-step reasoning, deep research, nuanced long-form writing, hard debugging            |
| <b>Premium</b><br><i>Fable 5</i>   | ● ● ● ● ●<br><i>~25× baseline</i> | Cutting-edge problems, highest-stakes creative or strategic work, when Advanced still falls short |

### 🔥 When in doubt, start with Standard (Sonnet 5)

It handles the vast majority of work (writing, analysis, coding, brainstorming) without burning through your budget. Step up to Advanced or Premium only when you've hit a wall.

**Hot Tip:** you can always upgrade mid-conversation without starting over.

*This document was mostly formatted and written with Sonnet 5!*